Class system for RPGs

Adding separate gameplay elements for different experiences.

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ABSTRACT

The game being made for our project is a new and innovative delivery simulator set in a fantasy setting that utilises standard RPG class mechanics and reputation systems and puts a twist on them to deliver the ultimate post office experience. This is a game that will be taking advantage of a genre that has only recently been introduced to the mainstream gaming community thanks to games like Death Stranding.[1]

Keywords

Skill tree, class resources, RPG class system.

1. INTRODUCTION

The aim of this short paper is to explore the similarities and differences of the class-based, or otherwise, skill tree systems in *The Elder Scrolls V: Skyrim*, *Yakuza 0*, and *Outriders* in order to determine the strengths and weaknesses of each system and provide a new and improved skill tree system that incorporates the best parts of each system.

2. FIELD

The field I am choosing to work in is a class system derived from RPGs. This is a system that will provide an aspect of progression from the player by rewarding them for playing the game by implementing various gameplay elements and features that either directly enhance or alter the main gameplay dynamics in a noticeable way. Additionally, these rewards will vary, depending on the class the player chooses to build their game around.

3. KEYPLAYERS

For each of the game examples below, they have a skill tree or progression system that tackles classes and playstyles in different ways and all three can be utilised in this report to help discern the specifics of how our game's class system will function.

3.1 Skyrim

Skyrim has a progression system where each action you perform and each achievement you obtain increases your level in a specific skill, allowing you to perform related actions easier or increase the proficiency of your expertise in the future.

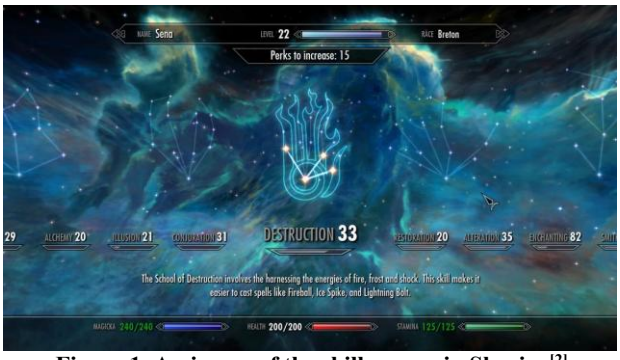

Figure 1. An image of the skills menu in Skyrim [2]

After increasing your proficiency in a specific skill enough, you can invest points into obtaining buffs, both for the respective skill and to upgrade your character's base stats after levelling up.

3.2 Yakuza 0

In Yakuza 0, both protagonists have skill trees for each of their 4 fighting styles. Unlike a normal skill tree, which uses a separate resource to purchase upgrades from a skill tree, you can directly purchase your skills using Yen, the form of money/currency in the game. Each node in the skill tree is colour-coded for the user to easily determine which nodes give what kind of upgrade.

Figure 2. The skill menu for the Beast fighting style in Yakuza 0[3]

Other than health upgrades, each skill upgrade is exclusive to the fighting style the skill is from. To gain the ability to purchase a skill, you must purchase any skills that come before and any other prerequisites, such as skills that require you to

train with a professional to unlock, also known as mastery skills. In later games, the developers include more skills that require the completion of an achievement, like defeating a certain enemy, for the player to purchase the skill.

3.3 Outriders

Outriders has a skill tree that is like other games, in which it has various nodes with either smaller upgrades to the characters attributes or more specific upgrades like new abilities and passives branching out.

Figure 3. The Trickster class tree in Outriders [4]

The thing that makes the Outriders' skill tree unique is that for each class, the nodes in the skill tree branch out before being focused into three individual paths, with a sub-class at the end that each vary in playstyle and specialisations. Additionally, there are points along the skill tree where the player can change paths midway through, in case they decided they want to change playstyle.

3.4 Summary

Skyrim gives the player 18 different skills, some tied to weapons and armour to help improve the efficacy of those items and some tied to specialisations and other skills, like alchemy or enchantment magic. As our game will be focussing on classes instead of specific skills, we won't have as many as 18 different stats to level up, but we will be using it as the basis for how the player unlocks each class. After performing specific actions, the player will receive experience points to progress the level of the action's respective skill. For example, if the player successfully delivers the correct letter to the correct character or does in a short amount of time, then the courier skill will gain experience and eventually level up. Once a player has achieved the skill requirements for a specific class, they will gain the ability to invest in upgrades for that class.

The thing that stands out the most about Yakuza 0's skill tree is the currency used in it. Each skill in the skill trees that is unlocked with money can be done so using several thousands of yen, which is on theme, considering that the protagonists of the game are yakuza, as the name suggests. While we will not be making all the upgrades in the game available using normal money, certain upgrades will be unlockable using the money you earn as a postman, such as the construction of the class-related buildings. This will strike a good balance as some specific but necessary upgrades should be locked behind the player's ability to do their job well.

The class trees from Outriders have many nodes that branch out into three paths for the player to take. Each path of nodes focuses on a different playstyle of either weapon damage, survivability, or anomaly power, which increases the damage dealt using skills and status effects. Once a player reaches the end of a path, they will obtain a respective subclass. Although our game will most likely not contain subclasses, separating and organising the upgrades in the class specific skill trees into groups or branches that are determined by playstyle will make it easier for the player to figure out which skills they wish to unlock. Additionally, to provide more build freedom, we will include from outriders the ability to re-specialise their skills as many times as the player wishes.

3.5 USP

The thing that made Skyrim so successful and popular is the sheer amount of freedom that the player has access to, from the size and scale of the map to amount of quests and outcomes for those quests.[5] The 18 skills mentioned prior help with this, because the number of different skills help provide additional gameplay elements for all players, regardless of playstyle. Each skill is levelled up passively, with the actions performed by the player more increasing the level of their respective skills further. This means that the level of a player's skills is entirely different to any other player at a similar point in the game. As we will have many outcomes for the player delivering mail successfully or otherwise, a sense of freedom will become important for both us and the players. This is why we will use a similar system at first before the player unlocks a class of their choice.

While Yakuza 0's skill tree does not directly relate to its success, one of its key elements could help with the identity our game has. The reason why Yakuza 0 and the rest of the series are so successful is because they are narratively driven games with good stories that strike an excellent balance between its seriousness and absurdity. Because of our game's amount of player expression and because of a couple classes in the game, we can take advantage of gamers' love for the absurd and use it to further their want to try more of the game.

Unfortunately, Outriders was not very successful past its initial 3.5 million players in its first month after release. This was mostly due to a launch that had many server issues and changes that made the game needlessly hard for newer players, all while the developers provided no communication with their community.[6] As our game will solely be a single-player experience, they should not be any server problems. Additionally, any big changes to the game will be explicitly communicated to the player-base.

3.6 Technologies

Our game is being made in the Godot game making engine with the intention of releasing the game on Steam, with the possibility of it being released later on Xbox and PlayStation consoles.

When the player is in the game, it will load the level of each skill, which will then be changed whenever the player performs specific actions. As the player earns experience points, the following four values will be stored locally: The current level, the maximum level, the experience points earned at the current level, and the experience points needed to level up. Once the player has certain skills at the correct level, the opportunity to purchase certain class buildings will appear to the player. If the player builds a class building, it will store locally which buildings have been unlocked and which building is currently built.

If the player has a class building built, they will have access to that building's respective class tree. This tree will be built up of

various nodes with their own data, including information like a name, a cost to unlock and its parents, also known as the prerequisite nodes in the skill tree. This will be paired with an adjacency list both to correctly pair a child with its parents and to make sure that each requirement is one-way. After accessing the class tree, the information of which nodes have been activated will be stored locally. Additionally, any changes to a player's abilities from the class tree will also be stored, instead of doing a check every time to see whether a character can walk 2 mph or 3mph.

3.7 Approach

During the initial inception process, we came up with 4 different classes for the player to switch between; the Wizard has access to some spells like fireball or summons that can be used in various ways like a toolbox when delivering, the Paladin has the ability to see the morality of the world's citizens and can choose to serve or smite the evil NPCs, the Tycoon has the ability to purchase additional tools and directly change the price of mail, and the Hermit gains strong upgrades and rewards at the expense of having to complete vague and open-ended challenges.

Figure 4. Table of the initial classes, their playstyles and any requirements

Class	Playstyle	Building Upgrade	Requisite skills
Wizard	Automation/sandbox	Wizard tower	Collection, informant
Paladin	Combat/"Papers Please" style activity	Chapel	Reputation, slayer
Tycoon	Resource management	Garage for carts	Courier, banker
Hermit	Challenge run/ creativity/ randomness	Large sign with a poster attached	Entropy, reputation

While the wizard does not receive any direct buffs with its book of spells, it has many tools at its disposal that can be used in many ways. The fireball can be used to dispatch enemies that appear on your way to deliver mail or to destroy the house of that one neighbour you don't like. The magic broom can get you to places faster, but you can only start flying from places high up. The summons can be created to perform any one task at a time, but is (hopefully) worse than the player performing the task themselves.

The paladin mostly gets upgrades for combat, as you will both need to vanquish enemies to move around easier and to obtain additional rewards for the paladin. The paladin is the class that is tied to the reputation system the most. The player can choose to defeat any evil villagers to increase their reputation with the rest of the town, but will not receive any other rewards, unlike if the player were to deliver mail instead, which would reward the player at the cost of lowered reputation.

As the tycoon is a class that directly revolves around money, the player will have a direct connection to the money they earn and spend. As the tycoon understands that the post office is a business first and foremost, they can directly change the amount that villagers pay to use your service. However, if the player increases the price too much, then they will have no customers. Additionally, the player can use the money they earn as the tycoon to purchase additional items, such as a cart to deliver more mail.

The hermit is a strange class that has very powerful upgrades, but needs to perform strange tasks in order to fully benefit from them. For example, there might be an upgrade that says "Gain double experience and money gained when delivering mail from behind."

4. CONCLUSIONS

I have learned from the games I have chosen that having the ability to upgrade skills and stats should feel rewarding, but not necessarily required to provide incentives to the player to continue playing and exploring the game. Giving the player freedom to choose how they play the game and effectively giving them a variety of ways to either augment or alter the game's main loop.

Through Skyrim, I have learned that simply giving players a select few skills to upgrade with points is all well and good, but should be directly tied to gameplay and should really feel like the character is actually gaining expertise in a given field. Yakuza 0 taught me that adding various arbitrary currencies is almost always inferior to a well-crafted and thematic experience. Because of Outriders, I realised that when creating a plethora of options for the player, arrangement is better than anarchy. The player should know exactly where to find what they want instead of having to guess.

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